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Closing the Gap: Scotiabank and the Next Generation Investor

This case was written for CaseHacks by Tarundeep Kaur, VP of Education, with input from Duncan Lu and the Scotiabank Digital Banking team. It was prepared for academic and competition purposes only.

In the spring of 2026, Ahmad Wali, a product analyst on Scotiabank's Digital Banking team, sat down to prepare a briefing for his VP. The prompt was straightforward: Scotiabank's 18-to-34 demographic was growing in deposit accounts, but investment product adoption within the same cohort had not kept pace. Meanwhile, Wealthsimple, a Toronto-based fintech founded just over a decade ago, had grown to serve more than 3 million Canadians and hold over \$100+ billion in assets under management³, built almost entirely on the demographic Scotiabank was struggling to convert from depositors into investors.

The question on the table was why a bank with nearly two centuries of history, a trusted national brand, a full product suite, and an existing relationship with millions of young Canadians was losing the investment conversation to platforms that had none of those advantages.

The data made the gap hard to ignore. A 2024 TD Bank Group survey found that a third of Canadians have never invested at all,¹ and CIRO's inaugural 2024 Investor Survey found that 43% of younger Canadians feel uncertain about where to even begin.² A 2025 study by Broadridge Financial Solutions found that among Gen Z investors, social media and financial influencers are now more popular sources of financial information than financial advisors, and one-third of Gen Z investors have never worked with an advisor at all.⁴ And with CPA Canada projecting that \$1 trillion in wealth will transfer from Baby Boomers to younger generations between 2023 and 2026,⁵ the institutions that build investment relationships with younger Canadians now will be best positioned to manage that capital for decades to come.

Scotiabank: Company Overview

The Bank of Nova Scotia, operating as Scotiabank, was founded in Halifax in 1832 and is one of Canada's oldest and largest financial institutions.⁶ Headquartered in Toronto, it is the third-largest Canadian bank by total assets and a permanent member of the Big Six, the six institutions that collectively hold the majority of Canada's banking assets.¹⁹

As of its fiscal year ending October 31, 2025, Scotiabank reported total assets of \$1.5 trillion, reported net income of \$7.8 billion (\$9.5 billion adjusted), a Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) ratio of 13.2%, and approximately 86,431 full-time equivalent employees across its global operations.^{6,7} The bank maintains branches and offices worldwide and serves customers across Canada, the United States, Latin America, the Caribbean, and select international markets.⁷

Scotiabank's Global Wealth Management division reported assets under management (AUM) of \$432 billion and assets under administration (AUA) of \$868 billion as of fiscal year-end 2025, representing 16% AUM growth year-over-year, driven by market appreciation and higher net sales.^{6,7} The division generated adjusted earnings of \$1.706 billion in 2025, up 17% year-over-year.^{6,7}

Scotiabank's GIC product range includes Non-Redeemable GICs (terms of 30 days to 5 years, minimum investment of \$500 for most term structures), Cashable GICs (1-year term, redeemable anytime after 30 days, minimum \$500), Personal Redeemable GICs (partially or fully redeemable before maturity at early redemption rates), and Market-Linked GICs (returns tied to a market index such as the S&P/TSX 60 or S&P 500, with a guaranteed minimum return).^{14, 15, 16}

Scotia Wealth Management

Scotia Wealth Management encompasses Scotiabank's full-service wealth advisory and portfolio management services for higher-net-worth individuals. Operating through the ScotiaMcLeod and Scotia Private Investment Counsel divisions, both part of Scotia Capital Inc., the division offers discretionary portfolio management, estate planning, tax advisory, and philanthropic giving strategies.¹⁷ ScotiaMcLeod advisors provide personalized investment counsel and manage client portfolios on a discretionary basis, drawing on the resources of Scotia Global Asset Management.¹⁷ Scotia Wealth Management is primarily oriented toward clients with significant existing assets; it is not the bank's primary entry point for younger or first-time investors.¹⁷

Registered Account Structures

Across all of the above product lines, Scotiabank supports the full range of Canadian registered investment account types, including the Tax-Free Savings Account (TFSA), Registered Retirement Savings Plan (RRSP), First Home Savings Account (FHSA), Registered Education Savings Plan (RESP), Registered Retirement Income Fund (RRIF), Registered Disability Savings Plan (RDSP), and non-registered investment accounts.^{8,14}

The Market Opportunity

Canada is in the midst of the largest intergenerational wealth transfer in its history. The Chartered Professional Accountants of Canada projected that \$1 trillion in wealth would move from Canadian Baby Boomers to their Millennial and Generation X heirs between 2023 and 2026.⁵ The financial institutions that build investment relationships with younger Canadians now are positioning themselves to manage and grow a significant share of that capital for the decades that follow.

The urgency is compounded by what research consistently shows about the persistence of financial relationships: customers who begin investing with a particular institution tend to remain with that institution as their portfolio grows. First-mover advantage in investment relationships is durable. Acquiring a young investor at the beginning of their financial journey has materially different long-term economics than acquiring the same customer a decade later.

A 2024 survey by TD Bank Group found that only 58% of Canadians make investments at least once a year, and that a third of Canadians (~34%) have never invested at all.¹ Among younger Canadians, the barriers to beginning are well-documented: nearly half of the same survey's respondents said they did not feel confident in their investment knowledge, and 30% reported having no investment plan.¹ Research from the Canadian Investment Regulatory Organization (CIRO) found that 43% of younger Canadians feel uncertain about where to begin when it comes to investing.²

The Competitive Landscape

Scotiabank competes for the investment assets of younger Canadians across two broad categories of institutions: the other members of the Big Six, each of which offers its own retail investment products, and a growing cohort of fintech and robo-advisor platforms that have built their products specifically around the needs of first-time investors. The distinction between these two categories matters: the Big Six compete on breadth, brand trust, and integration with full banking relationships; fintechs compete on simplicity, cost, and experience design.

Scotiabank trades on both the Toronto Stock Exchange (TSX: BNS) and the New York Stock Exchange (NYSE: BNS). Deposits are protected through the Canada Deposit Insurance Corporation (CDIC), and the bank operates under the regulatory oversight of the Office of the Superintendent of Financial Institutions (OSFI).

Scotiabank's Strategic Priorities

Scotiabank's vision is to be its clients' most trusted financial partner, guided by a simple purpose: "for every future." The bank's current strategy, launched at Investor Day in December 2023, is built around four pillars that reflect a deliberate shift in how Scotiabank thinks about growth.⁶

- *Grow and scale in priority markets:* deploying capital to priority businesses in Canada, the United States, and Mexico, strengthening North American corridor connectivity to accelerate growth.
- *Earn primary client relationships:* driving value over volume by building deeper, long-term relationships with clients and bringing the full strength of the bank to meet their evolving needs.
- *Make it easy to do business with us:* simplifying processes, driving operational excellence, and investing in digital capabilities so clients can bank with Scotiabank wherever and however they choose.
- *Win as one team:* investing in people and communities, fostering an inclusive, high-performance culture.

Scotiabank's Retail Investment Products

Scotiabank offers Canadian retail investors access to a suite of investment products spanning guided managed portfolios, self-directed brokerage, fixed-income instruments, and full-service wealth advisory. The primary retail-facing products are described below.

Scotia Smart Investor

Scotia Smart Investor is Scotiabank's digital investment platform, designed to guide customers through the process of setting, tracking, and adjusting financial goals.⁸ The platform is available to existing Scotiabank clients through online banking and allows users to link existing accounts or input details of external accounts to build a consolidated financial picture. The onboarding process involves a short questionnaire covering the user's savings goals, risk tolerance, and time horizon, after which the platform recommends an appropriate investment account type, such as a TFSA, RRSP, or FHSA, along with suitable products.⁸

Through Scotia Smart Investor, customers can access two primary managed portfolio solutions: Scotia Essentials Portfolios and Scotia Selected Portfolios.⁹ The platform reached a milestone of over one million financial goals created by clients since its launch, as of December 2024.⁸

Scotia iTRADE

Scotia iTRADE is Scotiabank's self-directed online brokerage platform, offering investors direct access to a broad range of securities, including Canadian and U.S. equities, ETFs, options, bonds, and GICs.¹¹ The platform is designed for investors who prefer to research and manage their own portfolios without the use of an advisor.

Scotia iTRADE offers commission-free trading on over 200 ETFs, provided the ETF is held for at least one full business day.¹² The platform supports TFSA, RRSP, RESP, FHSA, RRIF, and non-registered accounts, and is accessible through both desktop and a mobile application.¹¹

Guaranteed Investment Certificates (GICs)

Scotiabank offers several categories of Guaranteed Investment Certificates (GICs), which are secure, low-risk investments that guarantee the return of the investor's principal along with a fixed or variable rate of interest over a defined term.¹⁴ GICs are available in non-registered accounts and within registered plans, including TFSAs, RRSPs, RRIFs, RESPs, and RDSPs. All GICs with terms to maturity are eligible for CDIC insurance, subject to applicable limits.¹⁴

Fintech and Robo-Advisor Platforms

Beyond the Big Six, a set of technology-first platforms has gained significant market share among younger Canadian investors by offering lower fees, simpler onboarding, and mobile-first experiences that traditional banks have been slower to replicate.³

Wealthsimple

Founded in 2014, Wealthsimple has grown to serve more than 3 million Canadians and manage more than \$50 billion in assets across its platform as of the end of 2024.³ Its core managed investing product charges a management fee of 0.50% annually for accounts under \$100,000, dropping to 0.40% above that threshold, with no minimum investment required. The platform also offers self-directed trading (Wealthsimple Trade) with \$0 commissions on Canadian stocks and ETFs, and a cash account (Wealthsimple Cash) that functions as an interest-earning chequing account. Wealthsimple's defining characteristic is its onboarding and interface design: the platform uses plain language throughout, provides the option to invest into pre-defined portfolios based on the user's risk tolerance²⁵, and has invested heavily in financial education content through its magazine, newsletter, and social media presence.³

Questrade / Questwealth

Questrade is Canada's largest independent online brokerage, offering self-directed trading with commission-free ETF purchases (sells are \$4.95 to \$9.95) and a robo-advisor service called Questwealth Portfolios.¹⁸ Questwealth charges management fees of 0.20% to 0.25%, among the lowest in the Canadian market, and uses low-cost index ETFs from iShares, BMO, and Global X. The minimum to open a Questwealth account is \$250. Questrade positions itself as the cost-conscious alternative for investors who are financially literate enough to prioritize fees, and has found particular traction among Canadians in their late twenties and thirties who are actively seeking to minimize investment costs.¹⁸

The Customer: Young Canadian Investors

An extensive body of research exists on the financial attitudes and behaviours of younger Canadians. The findings paint an intricate picture: this cohort of Canadian's hold several different competing attitudes toward money and investing, which do not resolve neatly into a single strategic prescription.

Intention and Action

The relationship between awareness and action is one of the most consistent findings across recent Canadian financial research. A 2024 TD Bank Group survey of 2,695 Canadians found that 45% did not feel confident in their investment knowledge, and 30% had no investment plan at all.¹ Among those without a plan, 20% said they simply did not know where to begin, not that they lacked the funds.¹

The CIRO's inaugural 2024 Investor Survey reinforced this picture: 61% of non-investors cited a lack of funds as their primary barrier, while 43% of younger Canadians specifically reported feeling uncertain about where to start.² Separately, an Edward Jones survey of 1,516 Canadians conducted in late 2024 found that 84% believed that learning about money management in school would have helped them manage their personal finances with less stress today, and 64% said they had not received any financial literacy education during their schooling.²⁰

A follow-up Edward Jones survey conducted in February 2026 found that 84% of Canadians aged 18–34 report negative emotions about RRSP contributions, the highest rate of any age group, and that only 36% of adults aged 18–34 feel confident about basic retirement savings mechanics, compared to 69% of those aged 55 and older.²⁶

Taken together, these findings point consistently to the same underlying dynamic: the barrier to first investment among younger Canadians is more often confidence and clarity than it is capital. Many have money they could invest. But they are missing the important part of the puzzle: knowledge on whether they should, and how.

Trust and Platform Loyalty

Having a young Canadian's chequing account does not mean having their investment business. For this cohort, every product relationship starts from zero. The Canadian Bankers Association's 2024 *How Canadians Bank* study found that 70% of Canadians used a mobile app for banking in 2024, up from 65% in 2021, and that young adults aged 18–29 are more likely to be app-centric than any other age group.²² The same study found that the shift from online to app-based banking is accelerating, with 41% of Canadians expecting to increase their use of mobile banking apps in the next five years.²²

This digital fluency does not translate into institutional loyalty. A young customer may hold a chequing account at Scotiabank, invest through Wealthsimple, and use a separate budgeting application. The 2024 CSA Investor Index found that the sharpest drop in financial advisor use between 2020 and 2024 occurred among investors under 45 and those with portfolios under \$100,000, precisely the demographic that traditional banks need to capture at the start of their investment journey.⁴

Social Influence and Financial Information

The sources younger Canadians turn to for financial information have shifted significantly. The 2024 CSA Investor Index found that 53% of investors now use social media for investment information, an 18-point increase since 2020.⁴ Among investors aged 18 to 24, the figure reaches 82%, with YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok being the most common platforms.⁴ A November 2025 survey by the Financial Consumer Agency of Canada found that Canadians aged 18–34 are twice as likely as older Canadians to seek financial advice on social media, are the least likely demographic to consult a professional advisor, and are most likely to turn to family and friends for financial guidance.²³

At the same time, concern about the reliability of informal financial advice is rising. CIRO's 2024 survey found that while 38% of Canadians turn to family and friends for financial advice, many younger investors express anxiety about acting on advice from unqualified sources.² The institution that can offer authoritative, accessible, and plain-language financial guidance, rather than simply financial products, has a meaningful opportunity to capture trust at a formative moment in younger Canadians' financial lives.

The Intergenerational Wealth Transfer Context

The stakes of this dynamic extend beyond individual product adoption. TD Asset Management has noted that Baby Boomers currently control approximately 50% of Canada's total wealth, while Millennials, despite making up the largest share of the labour force, hold approximately 10%.²⁴ As the \$1 trillion intergenerational transfer projected by CPA Canada unfolds,⁵ the institutions already managing investment relationships with younger Canadians will be best positioned to retain the assets flowing to them. Those who have not yet established those relationships face a structural disadvantage that compounds over time.

The Situation

Young Canadians are investing. The data on Wealthsimple's user growth, Questwealth's low-cost traction, and the third of Canadians who have never made a single investment all point to the same underlying reality: demand for accessible investing exists, and it is being captured by platforms other than Scotiabank.

Scotiabank brings to this challenge assets that no fintech platform has replicated: 190 years of institutional trust, CDIC deposit protection, a full suite of registered account structures, a national branch and advisor network, and the deep banking relationships that come from being the primary financial institution for millions of Canadian households. It also enters this challenge with a defined strategy: one built around four pillars that shape where the bank is investing, how it thinks about growth, and what it means to earn a client relationship.

Any solution must be compatible with Scotiabank's regulatory environment and existing product infrastructure. It must be viable within an 18-month implementation horizon. And it must move the needle not just on account openings but also on sustained investment engagement that creates long-term client value.



Exhibits

Exhibit A: Selected Data

Key figures from publicly available sources providing quantitative context on Canadian investing behaviour, digital banking adoption, and market opportunity.

Metric	Figure
Canadians who have never invested (all ages, 2024) 1	34%
Canadians making investments at least once per year (2024) 1	58%
Canadians without an investment plan (2024) 1	30%
Canadians not confident in their investment knowledge (2024) 1	45%
Younger Canadians uncertain about where to begin investing 2	43%
Non-investors citing lack of funds as primary barrier 2	61%
Canadians who believe financial education in school would have helped 20	84%
Canadians who did not receive financial literacy education in school 20	64%
Canadians aged 18–34 reporting negative emotions about RRSP contributions 21	84%
Canadians aged 18–34 confident in basic retirement savings mechanics 21	36%
Canadians who used a mobile banking app in 2024 (up from 65% in 2021) 22	70%
Investors using social media for investment information (2024) 4	53%
Investors aged 18–24 using social media for investment information 4	82%
Canadian intergenerational wealth transfer (2023–2026, CPA Canada) 5	>\$1 trillion
Baby Boomer share of Canada's total wealth 24	~50%
Millennial share of Canada's total wealth 24	~10%
Wealthsimple Canadian clients (end of 2024) 3	3 million+
Wealthsimple assets under administration (end of 2024) 3	>\$50 billion
Scotiabank Global Wealth AUM (fiscal year-end 2025) 6, 7	\$432 billion
Scotiabank Global Wealth AUA (fiscal year-end 2025) 6, 7	\$868 billion

Exhibit B: Young Investor Sentiment Snapshot

Selected findings from third-party surveys on the financial attitudes, barriers, and behaviours of younger Canadians, with source attribution.

Finding	Source
34% of Canadians have never invested; only 58% invest at least once per year	TD/Maru Survey, 2024 1
45% of Canadians not confident in their investment knowledge	TD/Maru Survey, 2024 1
30% of Canadians have no investment plan; 20% don't know where to begin	TD/Maru Survey, 2024 1
61% of non-investors cite lack of funds as primary barrier to investing	CIRO Investor Survey, 2024 2
43% of younger Canadians feel uncertain about where to begin investing	CIRO Investor Survey, 2024 2
84% of Canadians believe financial education in school would have reduced financial stress	Edward Jones/Pollara, 2024 20
64% of Canadians say they received no financial literacy education in school	Edward Jones/Pollara, 2024 20
70% of Canadians used a mobile banking app in 2024, up from 65% in 2021; young adults 18–29 are the most app-centric group	Canadian Bankers Association, 2024 22
53% of investors use social media for investment information — up 18 pts since 2020	CSA Investor Index, 2024 4
82% of investors aged 18–24 use social media for investment information	CSA Investor Index, 2024 4
Sharpest drop in financial advisor use (2020–2024): investors under 45, portfolios <\$100K	CSA Investor Index, 2024 4
Baby Boomers hold ~50% of Canada's total wealth; Millennials hold ~10%	TD Asset Management 24
\$1 trillion in wealth to transfer from Boomers to younger generations (2023–2026)	CPA Canada, 2023 5

Sources

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[case]Hacks Submission Guidelines

Please read the guidelines carefully so your team knows what to submit, how to submit it, and what to expect on presentation day.

Key Information

- **Case Release:** May 23rd, 2026
- **Submission Deadline:** May 24th 2026 @ 10 AM
- **Submission Portal:** <https://casehacks-2026.devpost.com/>

All submissions must be uploaded through the official submission portal by the deadline. Late submissions may be penalized or, depending on the situation, may not be accepted.

Required Deliverables

Teams must submit two deliverables:

1. **Slide Deck** – Your slide deck should clearly explain your team’s solution and the thinking behind it, not simply summarize the case. Instead, tell a clear story: what problem you identified, why it matters, who it affects, and how your solution helps. Your slides should **include screenshots of your prototype** so judges can understand how your idea would look or work in practice.
2. **Prototype Screenshots or Quick Video** – Teams must submit screenshots (**separately in devpost other than in slides**) showing the key screens or user flow of their prototype. A short video walkthrough is optional, but screenshots are mandatory. The prototype does not need to be a fully built app. It just needs to make your idea feel real and show that your solution is feasible. Mockups made in Google Stitch, Codex, Lovable, Figma, or similar tools are completely acceptable.

File Naming Format

Please name your files using the following format:

TeamName_SlideDeck

TeamName_Prototype

Example:

caseHacks_SlideDeck

caseHacks_Prototype



[case]Hacks Submission Guidelines

Presentation Day

Each team will have **10 minutes to present, followed by a 5-minute Q&A** with the judges. The 10-minute limit will be strictly followed, and teams that go over time will be cut off.

Teams should arrive at least 15 minutes before their scheduled slot to check in and set up.

Please bring your own laptop. HDMI and USB-C adapters will be available. Prototype demos should be opened and ready before your pitch begins so setup does not take away from your presentation time.

Helpful Tips

- ★ A strong pitch does not need to be complicated. Focus on telling a clear story about the problem, your solution, and why it matters.
- ★ Your prototype does not need to be perfect or fully functional. It just needs to show the main idea and help judges understand how the solution would work.
- ★ Think like a product manager, not a full development team. We are more interested in your reasoning, user experience, feasibility, and impact than whether every button works perfectly.
- ★ Use your 10 minutes wisely. Focus on the most important parts of your solution instead of trying to explain every small detail.
- ★ The Q&A is not meant to trick you. It is a chance to show that your team understands your idea, your assumptions, and your numbers.
- ★ Most importantly, have fun with it. Hackathons are about creativity, problem-solving, and building something cool under pressure.

If you have any questions or concerns, feel free to reach out on discord and someone on the team will reach out and try to trouble shoot!

GOOD LUCK! AND HAVE FUN!!

